

IDENTIFYING RELAPSE TRIGGERS AND CUES

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Increase awareness of personal situational triggers and cues to relapse.
2. Recognize high-risk situations involving increased risk of relapse.
3. Develop coping skills to use when experiencing high-risk situations and/or craving.
4. Learn refusal skills for use when tempted to relapse into addictive behavior.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE RELAPSE PRONENESS

- A Working Recovery Plan
- Avoiding Nicotine Relapse Triggers
- Building My Support Network
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Coping with Post-Acute Withdrawal (PAW)
- Coping with Stress
- Early Warning Signs of Mania/Hypomania
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- Getting Out of Myself
- Personal Recovery Planning
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Relapse Prevention Planning
- Taking Daily Inventory
- Understanding Nonchemical Addictions
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- Using My Support Network
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Anxiety
- Eating Disorders

- Gambling
- Nicotine Dependence
- Opioid Dependence
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Sexual Promiscuity
- Substance Abuse/Dependence
- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal
- Treatment Resistance

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues” activity is designed to help the newly recovering client both to quickly identify environmental and internal relapse triggers, and to plan strategies to cope with them when they occur. Follow-up may include the “Relapse Prevention Planning” activity, keeping a journal about work with the information gained in this exercise, and reporting back to the therapist or group on outcomes of any strategies that are identified.

IDENTIFYING RELAPSE TRIGGERS AND CUES

Relapse is common, but it is preventable. To avoid relapse we have to stay aware of things that can trigger us to behave addictively and be willing to do something about it when one of them happens. This exercise will guide you in answering some questions so that you can become aware of your possible relapse triggers and make a plan to cope with them and prevent relapse.

Risky Situations

1. Relapse is often triggered by sights, sounds, and situations that have gone together with addictive behaviors in your past. Many recovering people find that unless they stay on guard, their thoughts automatically turn back to old behavior patterns when they are around the people with whom they drank, used, gambled, or whatever. Who are the people, or the kind of people, with whom you usually practiced addictive behaviors in the past?

2. Because addictive behaviors are sometimes social activities, you may know people who will expect you to continue to do the old things with them. They may not understand or care about your recovery, and may use persuasion, teasing, or argument to try to get you to relapse. In your life, who are the people most likely to pressure you to relapse?

3. Many recovering people find that others—family members, friends, or coworkers—have enabled their addictions by helping them avoid the consequences or by making it easier for them to keep doing the same things. Please list any people that have enabled you.

4. For each of the people listed previously—drinking/using/gambling companions, people pressuring you to relapse, and enablers—describe here how you will avoid relapse triggered by their actions.

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5. Changing the focus from people to situations, what are the social situations that you think will place you at greatest risk to relapse?

6. Many people also used addictions to cope with stress, and sometimes relationship issues can be extremely stressful. When you think about your future, how do you think relationship difficulties might put you at risk for returning to addictive patterns?

7. We also find that for many of us our addictions had become part of our daily routine, something we did automatically at certain times (e.g., just after work). Reviewing your daily routine, when during the day are you most likely to relapse?

8. Many people feel the urge to test their recovery in challenging situations (e.g., being with drinking friends, going to old hangouts). This is an unnecessary risk and often leads to relapse. Describe any ways in which you've tested your ability to stay in recovery.

9. To guard against stress-induced relapse, please think about current situations and future life events that you need to be ready to handle without escaping into addictions. What are they?

10. What's your plan to handle these situations? What changes are you willing and able to make to handle the pressures and temptations you've listed?

Internal Triggers

11. When you experience urges or cravings to act out addictively, how does your body feel?

12. When you experience urges to act out addictively, what emotions do you usually feel?

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13. As mentioned earlier, addictions are often tools for coping with stress (i.e., ways to change feelings that we dislike to ones with which we are more comfortable). What unpleasant feelings will place you at greatest risk for relapse?
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14. Following are some common feelings for which people have used chemicals to cope. It's important not only to be determined to avoid addictive behaviors, but also to know what you will do instead. If you don't have an alternative to replace substance abuse, your risk of relapse is high despite your willpower, logic, and good intentions. Next to each feeling, describe what you will do instead of acting out addictively to cope with that feeling.

Feeling	What You Will Do to Cope
a. Anger	
b. Anxiety	
c. Boredom	
d. Sadness	
e. Fatigue	
f. Fear	
g. Frustration	
h. Loneliness	
i. Indifference	
j. Self-pity	
k. Shame	
l. Depression	
n. Other feelings	

Be sure to bring this handout to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.